

[Return to Search](#)

Nyoro marriage and affinity

Author(S): Beattie, John

Document Type: Article

Original Page: 16

Culture (OWC): [Banyoro \(FK11\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1951-1955

Coverage Date: 1953

Place Coverage: Kihoko, Western Province, Uganda

Section Title(S): IV

I said above that a man calls all the men of his wife's agnatic descent group *baisezara*, and their wives *banyinazara*, but I added that there is a partial exception to this. A man calls his wife's sisters, and his brothers' wives, *baramu* (sing. *muramu*), or *baramukati* (i.e. *baramu* women). He also uses the term *baramu* for his wife's brothers, and his sisters' husbands. But his wife's brothers are men of his *isezara*'s agnatic group, and in certain situations they are also called *baisezara*.¹ And of course when *isezara* dies the son who is his heir automatically assumes *isezara*'s title and privileges.² Nevertheless in most informal everyday situations a man refers to and addresses his wife's brothers and his sisters' husbands as *baramu*. Now *muramu* is a reciprocal term, and to use it implies informality and equality. To quote an informant, when it is used between men 'it does not give great honour but makes one a brother to the other'. It is, however, my strong impression (though unfortunately one difficult to document) that the term *muramu* applies with some sort of primacy to an affine of the same generation of *opposite sex*, that is (for a man) to his wife's sister and his brother's wife.³ There is a saying that your *muramu* is the same as your wife (*muramu wawe mukazi wawe*), and a man may address his female *muramu* as 'my wife'. He may even call his wife's brother 'my wife', if he is only a young boy, or if they are particularly close friends. A man may marry two sisters, and such marriages are not uncommon; two of the 'plural wives' in Kihoko were sisters. Cohabitation with a wife's sister was not in any case seriously regarded traditionally, for she is also a 'wife' and can be so addressed. Correspondingly a wife could cohabit with her husband's brother (by the same father), for she is his 'wife' also. There is a Nyoro saying that it is well for a man who is going on a journey to leave his wife with his brother; if he sleeps with her it will not matter so much, for the blood will be the same as his own.⁴ It would be a very serious matter if she sought a lover elsewhere. Of course in present conditions these usages

171
[Comparative Evidence](#)

587
[Secondary Marriages](#)

595
[Polygamy](#)

601
[Kinship Terminology](#)

602
[Kin Relationships](#)

607
[Siblings-In-Law](#)

837
[Extramarital Sex Relations](#)

are becoming obsolete, if they have not already become so. But even today no native court would sustain a case for adultery damages against a full brother.

Thus a man thinks of his relationship with his female *baramu* as intimate and friendly; they are 'like wives'. He can talk and joke familiarly with them. These qualities also, in a large degree, characterize the relationship between male *baramu*. But a man's male *muramu* is at the same time either *muko* to the agnatic group to which that man belongs, or else he is one of the group of that man's *baisezara*. In either case he must be treated with something of the politeness and ceremony which we have seen to characterize the *isezara-muko* relationship, but which are conspicuously absent in the relationship between *baramu* of opposite sexes. The *baramu* relationship is between generational equals, and in it there is some relaxation of the formality and constraint and conscious status differentiation which characterize the relationship between the group which gives a woman and the group which receives her. So for all its stress on familiarity and equality the *baramu* relationship is not incompatible with the status distinction which we found to permeate the relationship between *isezara* and *muko*, though certainly it provides a partial exception to it. It is not so much that the status differentiation between the parties involved in the affinal relationship is absent in this particular situation. It seems rather that, in the relationship between members of the same generation, and in particular between persons of opposite sexes, this difference is partially submerged by the closer affective ties which are epitomized in the husband-wife relationship.

606

Parents-In-Law And
Children-In-Law

607

Siblings-In-Law

¹ For example if a man visits the home of a married brother of his wife he has to avoid that man's wife, for she is one of his *banyinazai* and he so refers to her. Thus his wife's married brother is in this context *isezara* rather than *muramu*. In Buganda a wife's brother is apparently referred to by the same term as a wife's father, *mukodomi* (cf. Roscoe, J., *The Baganda*, London, 1911, p. 131).

² Reciprocally, a man will in certain contexts regard the man who has married his sister as *muko*; he will certainly do so if he becomes his father's heir.

³ A number of thoughtful Banyoro to whom I put the suggestion agreed with it, but of course not too much should be inferred from this. It is worth noting, however, that according to Roscoe the neighbouring Baganda reserve the term *muramu* for the wife's sister, the wife's brother being called *mukodomi* (father-in-law). (Roscoe, op. cit., p. 131.)

⁴ Banyoro sometimes refer to such arrangements as 'to guard against the rats' (*kulinda mbeba*). Rats creep into houses while the owner is absent or asleep and bit by bit destroy his goods.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)